‘I told you she’s eager.’ He didn’t look at her until she screamed and said, ‘She’s coming NOW!’

The ambulance ride to the Military Hospital in Narangi was a very nervous one for Papaji. He knew Maa was in a lot of pain, even though she tried her best not to show it.

He knew there was nothing he could do except be by her side. ‘You’re a strong woman,’ he kept encouraging her. The hospital staff took Maa inside the labour room as Papaji’s friend, the army doctor, arrived. Five intense hours passed as a worried Papaji waited outside. He nervously paced the corridor, sweat covering his crew-cut hair and moustache. He prayed with each passing minute and waited. He didn’t even notice when my grandmother and little Dada arrived. Then came the moment he was longing for. The doctor came out of the room and Papaji paused mid-stride. ‘Congratulations, Captain,’ the doctor said cheerfully.

‘Is it a girl?’ Papaji waited for his reply.

‘It’s a boy,’ the doctor said, shaking his hand.

Papaji took a moment, and smiled only customarily before he replied plainly, ‘It’s okay . . . I’ll try again for a girl.’

At this the doctor burst into laughter, hugged Papaji, patted his back and said, ‘No need to try again . . . It’s a girl.’ On hearing this, Papaji smiled and hugged him back, blinked away his tears and then hurried into the labour room . . .

Captain Saxena and his wife spent the next few weeks tending to my needs. They took turns to look after both the kids. Grandmother was a big help in those days. Papaji implemented Dr Spock’s suggestions despite Grandmother’s protests. He made me sleep in a separate room, inside a crate, after a few months had passed. He kept their bedroom door open in case I cried in the middle of the night, which I’m sure I did quite often. At times, Dada pushed my pram and took me to either Maa or Papaji when I cried. In such instances, Papaji would proudly say to my grandmother, ‘See how Anshu is learning to take care of his sister when he cannot even speak yet. And you question *my* parenting.’ He would not let these incidents go